Q+A

WORDS OF WISDOM

*Veteran lyricist **Javed Akhtar**, who will soon receive the SOA Sahitya Samman 2025, talks about his lifelong contribution to Indian cinema and literature*



Q. How does it feel to be receiving the Siksha 'O' Anusandhan (SOA) Sahitya Samman this year?

One receives an award for work which has become disconnected from us. It is like getting a parent award for your child. One's intellectual umbilical cord gets cut off from the work once it's done. The work then acquires its own identity, and doesn't remain yours anymore. By the time it is appreciated by society, you have become a different person. So, to claim it totally is not fair.

Q. Poet, lyricist, scriptwriter, political activist—you wear many hats. Which role is closest to your heart?

Every person plays multiple roles in their life. For instance, someone could be a professional while being a daughter, a wife, a mother, a friend, a neighbour and a member of a certain society. This collage of different identities is what makes a person who they are. How can one decide which role they identify with most?

Q. Your family lineage can be traced back to seven generations of writers. Tell us about some of your earliest influences growing up.

If you are influenced by one, you are a plagiarist. If you are influenced by ten, you are a research scholar. Thankfully, I am influenced by many in my family. All these influences come together and make my writing.

Q. You have completed more than 50 years in the industry. Any favourites among the scripts you have worked on?

None. I don't watch my old films. My favourite scripts are in the future, which I am yet to write.

*—with **Neha Kirpal***

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**